

The foundation of this project is two works by Agatha Christie, *Murder on the Orient Express* and *The ABC Murders*. The former mainly serves as the form of expression for the entire project, which is a train, while the latter serves as the literary core of the project. The reason I chose *The ABC Murders* is somewhat strange, because three of the first four projects in this course were almost all related to letters. So for the final project, I also chose something strongly related to the letters in its title. *The ABC Murders* also fits what Jacquelyn Ardam described: “As such, a curious commonality among conceptual works has been overlooked: a striking number of them use the alphabetic sequence as formal scaffolding.” It is a work that uses alphabetical order as a formal framework for writing.

The original idea for this project was simply to have a train with the names of the three victims and one murderer from the original text written on it, and then put Agatha’s name at the front of the train, making it into something similar to a video. Essentially, it was meant to express the idea that every work is driven by its author. But when I read what Talan Memmott said in *New Media Poetics*, “Its performance or poetic emergence requires the participation of a user or operator to initiate the computational processes encoded by its author,” I thought that several of my previous projects, including the letter-related projects mentioned above, were also interactive, so I felt that continuing to make an interactive work would be better. However, the problem this created was that I could not let users know and enter the correct names, because I could not assume that everyone had read the book. But then I had a better idea: let the user act as the author and decide the names of the victims and the murderer. This makes it easier for the user to understand that the author is the main force pushing the plot of the work forward. Finally, asking the user to enter “ME” means that they themselves are the main force pushing the story forward.

When I was looking through materials about Agatha Christie, I found that she, or her company, had registered “Queen of Crime” as a trademark, and this is also one of the titles associated with her as a writer. This reminded me of when I was making a fan-fiction IF case for the *Danganronpa* series, which is a mystery game series. I often needed to put myself into the murderer’s perspective. As the “murderer,” how should I act, at what point in time should I act, how should I do it, who should my target be, and so on. This made me think that I, as the author, write the story, but I am also the “murderer” who kills the characters I write. This is why the ending has a kind of line spoken from the perspective of the “characters,” angrily accusing the author of treating their lives as disposable.

As for the opposite answer, “YOU,” it came from a video I happened to see. Two people were fighting, while a third person sat nearby eating snacks and simply watching. To be honest, videos like this are so common on the internet now that most people are no longer surprised by them. But just as I was about to scroll away, I saw a comment that said, “bloodthirsty audience be like:”. Unfortunately, I can no longer find that comment or video, but it gave me the idea for the second line of the project. In China, there is a public service advertisement with the slogan, “When the buying stops, the killing can too.” Its original purpose is to encourage people not to buy products made from rare animals, in order to stop the killing of endangered animals. So the idea behind my second line is that if there were not so many “bloodthirsty audiences,” then works that are “vulgar,” “bloody,” and “violent” would not be so widespread. This is a different conclusion from the original idea, but I think it is completely possible and appropriate for one work to produce two different understandings or responses.

The final lines, which are written almost like “poetry,” are meant to let the user know that the names they just entered now belong to people who have died. The feeling of placing them line by

line comes from the opening of many fictional crime television shows, where someone died in a certain place and at approximately a certain time. Although this is usually used as an opening, I also like the feeling of applying this kind of opening structure to an ending. In terms of time, the second case uses the computer's local time when the program is running. The first case takes place on the previous day, at the current time minus N hours. The third case is the opposite, taking place on the next day and at the current time plus N hours. The basic meaning is to represent the past, present, and future. There is no deeper meaning in this part. I simply think it makes the whole project more interesting.

After the project was mostly complete, I still went back and thought about it. This was originally a work paying tribute to Agatha Christie, and if the elements from the original work were removed until only the victims' initials and the murderer's alphabetical order remained, I would consider the project a failure. So in the end, I added an Easter egg. If the names of all three victims and the "murderer" are the names from the original work, then the final input at the front of the train cannot longer be "ME" or "YOU," but "AGATHA." The final text will also change. The last change I want to mention is the cause of death. The cause of death was not actually included in the project list at the beginning. I first added it because I hoped the cause of death could interact with the location and time, creating a feeling similar to an ARG (alternate reality game). I later removed it because, during testing and feedback, it was unable to produce the intended effect together with the place names, while also making people feel confused.